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THE INTERNATIONAL FOOTBALL ASSOCIATION BOARD



Laws of the Game 26/27



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The International Football Association Board

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Effective from 1st July 2026

Laws
of the Game
2026/27

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About the Laws



The philosophy and spirit of the Laws

Football is the greatest sport on earth. It is played on every continent, in every country and at many different levels. The fact that the Laws of the Game are the same for all football throughout the world, from the FIFA World Cup™ through to a game between young children in a remote village, is a considerable strength which must continue to be harnessed for the good of football everywhere.

Football must have Laws which keep the game fair – this is a crucial foundation of the ‘beautiful game’ and a vital feature of the spirit of the game. The best matches are those where the referee is rarely needed because the players play with respect for each other, the match officials and the Laws.

Football’s Laws are relatively simple compared to most other team sports, but as many situations are subjective and match officials are human, some decisions will inevitably be wrong or cause debate and discussion. For some people, this discussion is part of the game’s enjoyment and attraction but, whether decisions are right or wrong, the spirit of the game requires that referees’ decisions must always be respected. All those in authority, especially coaches and team captains, have a clear responsibility to the game to respect the match officials and their decisions.

The Laws cannot deal with every possible situation, so where there is no direct provision in the Laws, The IFAB expects the referee to make a decision within the spirit of the game and the Laws – this often involves asking the question, ‘what would football want/expect?’

Poor participant behaviour and intentional delays that disrupt the flow of the game remain two major concerns. Following the successful implementation of the ‘Only the captain’ guidelines, as well as the measure that penalises goalkeepers who hold the ball for more than eight seconds by awarding a

corner kick to the opposition, further steps have been taken to address deliberate tempo disruption and time lost. Referees have now been given enhanced authority to combat time-wasting tactics involving throw-ins, goal kicks, injuries and substitutions.

The Laws must also contribute to the safety and welfare of players and it is The IFAB's responsibility to react quickly and appropriately to support the game's participants, through the Laws themselves, when the need arises.

To that end, competitions have the option of allowing the use of 'additional permanent concussion substitutions'. This enables teams to prioritise the welfare of a player who has an actual or suspected concussion without suffering a numerical disadvantage.

Accidents inevitably occur, but the Laws aim to help make the game as safe as possible, balancing player welfare and sporting fairness. This requires referees to use the Laws to deal strongly with those players whose actions are too aggressive or dangerous. The Laws embody the unacceptability of unsafe play in their disciplinary phrases, such as 'reckless challenge' and 'endangering the safety of an opponent' or 'using excessive force'.

To promote a greater understanding of the Laws, The IFAB has published 'Football Rules – simplified Laws of the Game', which have been written to make the Laws easier to understand, especially for young people, potential or newly qualified referees, adults who referee occasionally, players, coaches, spectators and the media.

Visit **www.footballrules.com** to access or download Football Rules, which can be sorted alphabetically or by category.

An audio version of the Laws of the Game can be accessed at:
www.theifab.com.



Managing changes to the Laws

Football must remain attractive and enjoyable for players, match officials and coaches, as well as spectators, fans and administrators, regardless of age, gender, race, religion, culture, ethnicity, sexual orientation or disability.

It is also crucial to uphold the universality of the Laws to allow young players to watch matches on television and then attempt to replicate what they have seen on the field. Therefore, any changes to the Laws must benefit the game as a whole, which often requires testing or trialling the proposed modifications first.

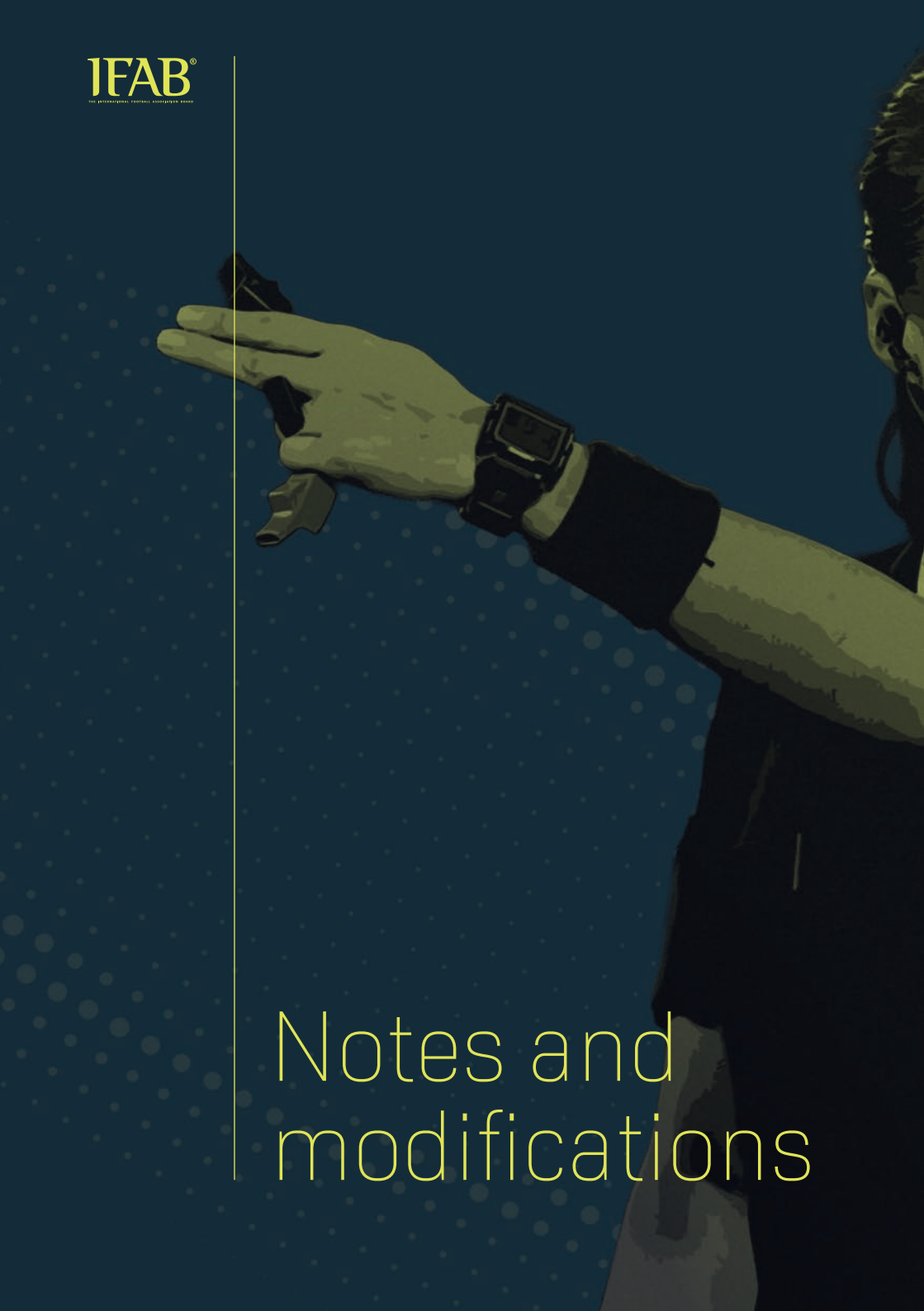
For every proposed change, the focus is on fairness, integrity, respect, safety, the enjoyment of participants and spectators and, where appropriate, using technology to enhance the game.

The IFAB will continue to work with its advisory panels and engage in extensive consultations with stakeholders so that changes to the Laws benefit football at all levels and in every corner of the world. This should help ensure that the integrity of the game, the Laws themselves and the match officials are respected, valued and protected.

The IFAB greatly values its engagement with people worldwide and is always happy to receive suggestions or questions relating to the Laws of the Game. Please continue to send your ideas, suggestions and questions to:
lawenquiries@theifab.com.

For more information on the history of the Laws of the Game and current developments, including trials, please visit our website: **www.theifab.com**.





Notes and modifications

Notes on the Laws of the Game

Official languages

The IFAB publishes the Laws of the Game in English, French, German and Spanish. If there is any divergence in the wording, the English text is authoritative.

Other languages

National football associations (FAs) which translate the Laws of the Game can obtain the layout template for the 2026/27 edition of the Laws from The IFAB by contacting: info@theifab.com.

National FAs which produce a translated version of the Laws of the Game using this format are invited to send a copy to The IFAB (stating clearly on the front cover that it is that national FA's official translation) so it can be posted on The IFAB's website for use by others.

Measurements

If there is any divergence between metric and imperial units, the metric units are authoritative.

Applying the Laws

The same Laws apply in every match in every confederation, country, town and village and, apart from the modifications permitted by The IFAB (see 'General modifications'), **the Laws must not be modified or changed, except with the permission of The IFAB.**

Those who are educating match officials and other participants should emphasise that:

- referees should apply the Laws within the 'spirit' of the game to help produce fair and safe matches

- everyone must respect the match officials and their decisions, remembering and respecting that referees are human and will make mistakes

Players have a major responsibility for the image of the game and the team captain should play an important role in helping to ensure that the Laws and referees' decisions are respected.

Key

The main Law changes are underlined in yellow and highlighted in the margin. Editorial changes are underlined.

YC = yellow card (caution); RC = red card (sending-off).



General modifications

The universality of the Laws of the Game means that the game is essentially the same in every part of the world and at every level. As well as creating a fair and safe environment in which the game is played, the Laws should also promote participation and enjoyment.

Historically, The IFAB has allowed national football associations (FAs) some flexibility to modify the 'organisational' Laws for specific categories of football. The IFAB strongly believes that national FAs should be able to modify some aspects of the way football is organised if it will benefit football in their own country.

How the game is played and refereed should be the same on every football field in the world, from the FIFA World Cup™ final to the smallest village. However, the needs of a country's domestic football should determine how long the game lasts, how many people can take part and how some unfair behaviour is punished.

All national FAs (and confederations and FIFA) have the option to modify all or some of the following organisational areas of the Laws of the Game for football for which they are responsible:

For all levels of the game:

- the number of substitutes each team is permitted to use in official competitions up to a maximum of five*, except in youth football, where the maximum will be determined by the national association, confederation or FIFA
- the use of additional permanent concussion substitutions (applying The IFAB's protocol)
- the implementation of the 'Only the captain' guidelines (this will be compulsory for all competitions starting on or after 1st July 2027)

**See also Law 3 for the conditions that apply to matches that go to extra time and details on the restriction on substitution opportunities.*